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The Cookie Cash Blueprint™ · Cookie Cash Academy™

 MAIN PRODUCT

The *Cookie Cash* Method

The six-module system that takes you from an empty kitchen counter to a 100-cookie order booked, produced and paid. No storefront, no quitting your day job, no professional pastry training.

- Three base dough recipes that hold their shape — vanilla, chocolate and gluten-free
- Professional royal icing with three consistencies and exact ratios
- Ten decorating techniques, from the simplest to the highest-selling
- Drying, packaging, pricing and selling — closing the loop on your first paid order

Method course · Main product

2026 edition · Margaret Whitaker

Main product of the system

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*This PDF is not a recipe book. It's a method. Each module closes the previous one and opens the next, and by the end of the six you'll have not one recipe but a **complete process** that starts on the counter and ends with a paid invoice. Read it end to end before you start. Then come back module by module as you practise. The five bonuses that ship with this method each unblock a different bottleneck — supplies, presentation, preservation, pricing and sales.*

PROLOGUE

Why cookies and not something else

The concrete reason this business fits in your kitchen, your schedule and your budget — and why you haven't started yet.

Before I hand you a single recipe, I want us to be clear on why this works. Not because it's "a nice idea." Because the product, the margin, the demand and the schedule all pull in your favour. All four together. Very few home-based food businesses check all four boxes.

The first reason: it fits in your real kitchen

You don't need a commercial mixer. You don't need a walk-in cooler. You don't need a licensed commercial kitchen to start selling to friends, family and coworkers (rules vary by state and country — the Cottage Food laws in the US, Home Baker registration in the UK, and Class 4 permits in most Australian states cover the vast majority of readers). A domestic oven, a clean countertop and two baking sheets are enough to produce 24 cookies per batch. In six batches on a Saturday you have 144 decorated cookies ready to hand off on Monday. That's the real starting volume for a home baker. It's not a course fantasy — it's what our students measure in their kitchens month after month.

The second reason: the margin absorbs ingredient inflation

A standard decorated cookie (roughly 3 inches / 7-8 cm) has a direct ingredient cost that lands between 12 and 18 percent of its retail price. That means every dollar coming in leaves between 80 and 88 cents on the table before you deduct your hourly rate, your oven gas or electricity, and packaging. Compare that to a decorated cake: same category, tighter margin, higher risk of collapse or melt in transit. Decorated cookies don't. They hold, they travel, they store, they sell.

The third reason: demand is not seasonal

Birthdays happen twelve months a year. Baby showers, weddings, corporate events, first communions and confirmations, anniversaries, gender reveals, engagement parties, kids' school parties, teacher-appreciation gifts, Valentine's, Easter, Halloween, Thanksgiving, Christmas — every one of these events wants decorated cookies. December peaks (Christmas plus New Year), Valentine's peaks, Easter peaks. But even the quiet months in between hold volume. And since 2020 the American, British, Canadian and Australian consumer has fully absorbed the habit of ordering baked goods from a home baker via Instagram DM or a texted photo. That habit is not going away.

The fourth reason: you can start with almost no money

The starter ingredient kit for your first four batches costs under \$80 USD (equivalents in GBP, CAD, AUD are in [Bonus 2 · Sourcing Supplies](#)). With that you produce your first 96 cookies, take your first paid orders, and use that cash to buy for your second run. You build working capital yourself by staging small orders at the start. There's no scary upfront investment. This is the least capital-intensive way into home baking, period.

BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE — A SMALL COMMITMENT TO YOURSELF

This method works if you actually work it. You'll read everything, nod, say "cool", and close the PDF. If that happens, you learned nothing. Commit to this instead: **in the next seven days you will bake at least one batch from Module 1 and mix one test batch of icing from Module 2.** No decorating yet, no selling to anyone. Just that. If you do it, you'll keep going. If you don't, this PDF becomes another file. The difference between the students who invoice and the ones who don't is exactly that first Saturday of practice.

Who I am and why I write this way

My name is Margaret Whitaker. I'm 54, I live in a mid-sized town, and I baked my first decorated batch in 2013 for my youngest daughter's birthday. In 2017 I stopped working my administrative day job. By 2021, on a home-baker license and a domestic oven, I was invoicing months that beat any year I'd ever pulled in employment. This method is literally what I did, ordered into six teachable steps. There are no grandmother's secrets in here. There is *process*. Process is something anyone can learn. That's the whole point.

US / UK TERMINOLOGY NOTE — READ THIS ONCE

Throughout this method I use dual terminology when the ingredient name changes across countries. **Powdered sugar** (US) is **icing sugar** (UK/CA/AU). **All-purpose flour** (US/CA) is **plain flour** (UK/AU). **Corn starch** (US) is **corn flour** (UK/AU). **Baking soda** (US/CA) is **bicarbonate of soda** (UK/AU). Where a difference matters I write both. Weights are given in grams first (accurate, universal) with US customary in parentheses. If you're American and you don't own a kitchen scale, buy one for \$12 before you bake your first batch. Baking by volume is where amateur cookies come from.

The base dough — three recipes that hold

Classic vanilla, chocolate and gluten-free. All three follow the same logic: a firm dough that keeps its shape in the oven and a crumb that carries the weight of the icing without cracking.

A decorated cookie starts with a cookie whose edges come out of the oven straight. That's the target. If your edges come out rounded or puffed, the icing won't cover them cleanly and the piece will look amateur. These three recipes are calibrated so that doesn't happen.

1.1 • The logic of a dough that decorates well

Two things kill a decorating cookie: **too much leavening agent** (puffs and deforms) and **butter that's too soft** (spreads in the oven). All three recipes below use little to no baking powder and start with cold butter straight from the fridge. That's the key. Respect the butter temperature and the fridge rest, and your edges will come out straight. Skip it and they won't.

1.2 · Recipe 1 · Classic vanilla (the one that sells itself)

Classic vanilla · yields 24 cookies at 3 inches / 7-8 cm

All-purpose flour (plain flour UK)	350 g / 2¾ cup	Cold unsalted butter (fridge cold)	150 g / ⅔ cup
Powdered sugar (icing sugar UK)	150 g / 1¼ cup	Large egg	1
Vanilla extract (pure, not imitation)	1 tsp	Fine salt	1 pinch

- 1 In a bowl, work the cold cubed butter into the flour, powdered sugar and salt using only your fingertips until the mix looks like coarse breadcrumbs. Don't knead yet.
- 2 Add the lightly beaten egg with the vanilla and bring together with a spatula. Finish by hand and stop the second the dough forms a ball. **Never knead for more than 30 seconds.** Over-kneading activates gluten and gives you a hard, cracker-like cookie.
- 3 Wrap the ball in cling film (plastic wrap) and fridge it **at least 40 minutes**. Two hours is better. This rest is non-negotiable: if the butter isn't cold when you roll, the cookie will spread.
- 4 Roll the dough between two sheets of parchment (baking paper) to a uniform **5 mm / ¼ inch** thickness. Cut with your chosen cutter. Scraps go back in the fridge for 10 minutes before you re-roll them.
- 5 Place the cut pieces onto a cold parchment-lined baking sheet. Freeze for **15 minutes** before baking. This second chill is what locks the edges.
- 6 Bake at **170 °C / 340 °F** for **10 to 12 minutes**, until the edges take on the palest golden colour. Never a deep bake — decorating cookies come out of the oven pale.
- 7 Rest on the sheet 5 minutes. Then transfer to a wire rack and wait until they're **completely cool to the touch** (minimum 30 minutes) before icing. Never decorate warm cookies.

THREE TYPICAL MISTAKES WITH THIS RECIPE

(1) Using room-temperature "soft" butter because you don't want to wait. Result: deformed edges. (2) Kneading for two minutes "for a smoother dough." Result: cookies as hard as crackers. (3) Pulling the tray out when the tops look golden. Result: over-baked, brittle cookies that snap when you box them up.

1.3 · Recipe 2 · Chocolate (the top seller for kids' parties)

Chocolate · yields 24 cookies at 3 inches / 7-8 cm

All-purpose / plain flour	300 g / 2⅔ cup	Unsweetened cocoa powder (dark)	50 g / ½ cup
Cold unsalted butter	150 g / ⅔ cup	Powdered / icing sugar	150 g / 1¼ cup
Large egg	1	Vanilla extract	1 tsp
Fine salt	1 pinch		

- 1 Sift flour, cocoa and salt together. Cocoa clumps hard if you skip the sift and you'll see dark specks in the dough.
- 2 Same fingertip technique as vanilla — cold cubed butter, powdered sugar, dry mix. Bring together with the egg.
- 3 Fridge rest **at least 1 hour** (chocolate dough needs a longer chill because cocoa softens the butter).
- 4 Roll to **5 mm / ¼ inch**, cut, freezer 20 minutes.
- 5 Bake at **165 °C / 330 °F** for **10 to 11 minutes**. You can't rely on colour with chocolate — press the edge gently, if it's firm and doesn't dent, they're done. Don't over-bake or they'll be brittle.
- 6 Cool same as vanilla — 5 minutes on the sheet, then rack, then decorate cool.

THE WHITE-ICING-ON-CHOCOLATE DETAIL

On chocolate cookies white royal icing has to be *opaque*. If yours looks slightly translucent, the brown shows through and the piece looks amateur. Fix: add a pinch of food-grade titanium dioxide (sold as "bright white" gel at Wilton, AmeriColor and most cake-decorating suppliers) or simply increase the powdered-sugar ratio in your icing by 10%. Small detail, big visual jump.

1.4 • Recipe 3 • Gluten-free (opens roughly 30% more market)

Gluten-free • yields 22 cookies at 3 inches / 7-8 cm

Gluten-free 1:1 baking blend (King Arthur / Bob's Red Mill / Doves Farm UK)	320 g / 2½ cup	Corn starch (corn flour UK)	40 g / ⅓ cup
Xanthan gum	1 tsp	Cold unsalted butter	160 g / ¾ cup
Powdered / icing sugar	140 g / 1 cup + 2 tbsp	Large egg	1
Vanilla extract	1 tsp	Fine salt	1 pinch

- 1 Whisk the dry ingredients together, including the xanthan gum (this is what replaces the elasticity of gluten in this dough — skip it and the cookie crumbles).
- 2 Same fingertip method. Bring together with the egg + vanilla.
- 3 Fridge rest **at least 90 minutes**. GF doughs need more time to hydrate.
- 4 Roll to **5 mm / ¼ inch**. Be gentle — GF dough tears more easily than wheat dough. If it does tear, patch it with a fingertip and roll over it once. It will fuse.
- 5 Cut, freezer **25 minutes** (longer than the other two — GF needs more chill before the oven).
- 6 Bake at **170 °C / 340 °F** for **11 to 13 minutes**. Same doneness cue as chocolate: press the edge, must be firm.
- 7 Cool. GF cookies feel softer than wheat when warm — that's normal, they firm up as they cool.

ALLERGEN AND CROSS-CONTAMINATION — READ BEFORE SELLING GF

If you're going to sell to customers with genuine celiac disease (as opposed to gluten-sensitivity by choice), you need to be honest about your kitchen. Baking gluten-free in the same kitchen where you bake wheat means cross-contamination unless you fully clean surfaces, use dedicated utensils and bake GF first before wheat has been on the counter that day. Print a label that reads **"Made in a kitchen that also handles wheat"** for every gluten-free order. Celiac customers appreciate the honesty and will still buy from you. Pretending your kitchen is dedicated when it isn't will eventually put someone in hospital and end your business. This is the one rule I refuse to soften.

1.5 • Common variables and how to control them

VARIABLE	EFFECT IF WRONG	FIX
Warm butter (over 15 °C / 59 °F)	Cookies spread and deform	Cube fridge-cold butter, work fast, chill dough longer
Over-kneading (more than 30 seconds)	Hard, cracker-like cookies	Stop the second the ball forms
Dough not chilled enough	Rolls unevenly, deforms in oven	Minimum 40 min fridge rest for vanilla, 60 min for chocolate/GF

VARIABLE	EFFECT IF WRONG	FIX
Cut pieces not frozen before baking	Edges round out during baking	15-25 min freezer rest, non-negotiable
Oven too hot	Dark undersides, pale tops	Buy an oven thermometer for \$6. Most home ovens are 15-25 °C off
Baking too long	Brittle, cracks under icing weight	Pull them out pale — they'll firm up on the sheet
Decorating warm cookies	Icing melts and slides	Cool 30 min minimum. Ideally overnight for best-looking icing

1.6 • Yields per batch and per Saturday

One home oven with one baking sheet at a time yields these numbers if you don't rush:

- **Single batch (1 dough recipe):** 22-24 undecorated cookies · 60 min hands-on + 90 min chill.
- **Three batches (one Saturday morning):** 66-72 cookies · 3.5 hours total including two ovens overlaps.
- **Six batches (a full baking Saturday):** 132-144 cookies · 6-7 hours. This is a solid week's production if you decorate Sunday.

MILESTONE FOR MODULE 1

Before you move to Module 2, bake at least one full batch of vanilla (Recipe 1). Look at the edges. Take a photo. If they're straight, you're ready. If they're puffed or rounded, don't move on — go back to the fridge-rest and freeze steps and try again. Module 2 will punish sloppy edges.

MODULE 2

Professional royal icing

The one recipe you'll rewrite twenty times in your first year — and the three consistencies you need to decorate everything from a monogrammed wedding favour to a Halloween sugar skull.

Royal icing is where amateurs plateau. The recipe is short. The technique is not. Nail this one module and everything in Module 3 becomes accessible.

2.1 • The base recipe

Royal icing base • covers roughly 24-28 cookies

Powdered / icing sugar (sifted)	500 g / 4 cups	Meringue powder (Wilton / Squires Kitchen)	3 tbsp / 22 g
Warm water (starting quantity)	75 ml / 5 tbsp	Clear vanilla or almond extract (optional)	½ tsp

- 1 Sift the powdered sugar. Any clumps become gel-line clogs later.
- 2 In the bowl of a stand mixer with paddle attachment (not whisk), mix the sifted sugar with the meringue powder for 30 seconds at low.
- 3 Add half the water. Mix low for 2 minutes. Add the rest gradually until you reach **stiff-peak consistency**: the icing holds a sharp point when you lift the paddle.
- 4 Beat on medium-low for **4 to 5 minutes total**. Not longer. Over-beating incorporates air, which gives you bubbles and craters in your flood work.
- 5 Cover the bowl with a damp cloth the second you finish. Royal icing crusts within 90 seconds of air exposure.

MERINGUE POWDER VS. FRESH EGG WHITE — THE HONEST ANSWER

Fresh egg white gives you the best texture, but for selling in the US, UK, Canada and Australia I'd point you to meringue powder every time. Reason: pasteurised, shelf-stable, doesn't carry salmonella risk, and customers with pregnancy or immune concerns can eat your cookies without a warning label. In the US you can also use pasteurised egg white powder (Wilton Bright White). In the UK, Squires Kitchen Merri-White is the equivalent.

2.2 • The three consistencies you will use every session

The same base recipe becomes three different tools depending on how much water you add after mixing. Master these three and you decorate 95% of what customers ask for.

CONSISTENCY	RATIO WATER ADDED	TEST	USED FOR
Stiff (piping)	0 — base recipe as-is	Holds a sharp peak. Doesn't fall off a spoon.	Outlines, details, roses, text, borders
Medium (flooding thick)	+ 1 tsp water per cup	Ribbon settles in 10-15 seconds when drizzled	Flooding tight areas, thick borders
Flood (thin)	+ 2-3 tsp water per cup	Ribbon settles in 5-7 seconds when drizzled	Filling large surfaces, wet-on-wet backgrounds

The industry names these "10-second," "15-second," and "20-second" icing (referring to how many seconds it takes the ribbon to settle back into the surface). Ignore the exact numbers and learn the visual instead — every batch of icing behaves slightly differently depending on humidity.

2.3 · Colouring — the three brands worth buying

Only gel colours. Never liquid food colouring — it destroys the water balance of your icing.

- **AmeriColor (US, ships globally):** the industry standard. Deep, saturated, doesn't fade. Start with a set of 12 basic colours.
- **Wilton (US/CA):** more accessible retail, slightly less pigmented than AmeriColor but perfectly usable.
- **Sugarflair or ProGel (UK/EU):** UK bakers' choice. Slightly different palette but same category.
- **Fractal Colors (AU):** Australian equivalent, common in Squires Kitchen AU distribution.

DARK COLOUR WARNING — READ BEFORE YOU START ON BLACK OR RED

To hit true black or true red you'll need *a lot* of gel. This bitters the icing. Two fixes: (1) mix the dark colour the night before and let it deepen overnight — the colour intensifies as it rests, so you use less gel. (2) Add a drop of clear almond extract to mask the bitter. Never try to make black by mixing red, blue and green — you'll get a muddy grey.

2.4 · Piping bags, tips and workflow

The debate between reusable and disposable piping bags is settled: disposable. You'll go through 20-30 per weekend and the wash-and-dry time isn't worth it.

- Disposable 12-inch (30 cm) piping bags, tiptless. A #2 or #3 tip in the corner of the bag is optional — for tight detail you can just snip the tip of the bag to size.
- For outlines: a small hole cut at the bag corner (~2 mm) or a #2 tip.
- For flooding: a slightly bigger hole (~3-4 mm) or a #3 tip.
- For fine text and monograms: #1 or #1.5 tip.

2.5 · Common icing problems — troubleshooting

SYMPTOM	CAUSE	FIX
Craters and dents on flooded surface	Air bubbles from over-mixing or from vigorous piping	Beat 4-5 min max. Pop bubbles with a toothpick within 20 sec of flooding.
Icing tears when flooded	Too thick — needs more water	Add water 1 tsp at a time, mix gently, retest ribbon

SYMPTOM	CAUSE	FIX
Icing spreads past the outline	Too thin, or outline dried too long before flooding	Thicken slightly, flood within 10 min of outlining
Colour "bleeds" between adjacent flooded areas	Flooded the second colour while the first was still wet	Wait 45-60 min between adjacent flood colours
Icing "cracks" as it dries	Too thick a flood layer, or humidity too high	Flood in thinner layers, dry near a fan or dehumidifier
White icing looks translucent on chocolate cookie	Under-pigmented white	Add "bright white" gel or increase sugar 10%

2.6 · Storage and shelf life of icing

Prepared royal icing in an airtight container with plastic wrap pressed directly on the surface keeps **2 weeks refrigerated** or **3 months frozen**. Re-whip briefly (30 seconds low) before using. Coloured icing keeps the same but always mix a small test batch to verify colour depth hasn't shifted — some pigments deepen in the fridge, especially reds and blacks.

Ten decorating techniques

From the outline-and-flood that every professional cookie starts with, to painted florals and hand-piped monograms. In order of difficulty — start at the top and work down.

You don't need all ten techniques to run a business. You need the first three to sell your first hundred cookies, and the middle four to reach a \$6-9 per unit price point. The last three are what separate you from every other home baker in your area.

3.1 • Technique 1 • Outline and flood (the foundation)

This is the single most valuable skill in this method. Ninety percent of what customers order — birthday cookies, corporate logos, wedding monograms, holiday shapes — is a version of outline-and-flood.

1. Load stiff icing into a bag with a #2 tip. Pipe the outline along the very edge of the cookie, following the shape closely.
2. Wait 3-5 minutes for the outline to set slightly (touch-tacky, not fully dry).
3. Switch to flood consistency. Fill the outlined space in a zig-zag or spiral pattern from centre outward, never overshooting the outline.
4. Use a toothpick or a scribe tool to guide the flood into corners and pop any air bubbles.
5. Tap the cookie gently on the counter to level the surface.
6. Let dry **at least 8 hours** in a low-humidity area before adding any detail on top.

3.2 • Technique 2 • Wet-on-wet

The dot-and-drag technique for backgrounds that look impossible but take 20 seconds. While the flood is still wet, place small dots of a second colour and drag a toothpick through them to create marbling, hearts (dot + drag = heart), swirls, tie-dye. Because both colours are wet, they merge visually but stay in place. This is the technique for Valentine's, gender-reveal and baby-shower orders.

3.3 • Technique 3 • Layered flood (dimension)

Flood the base colour, let it dry completely (8+ hours), then flood a smaller shape on top in a different colour. Because the base layer is fully dry, the two sit as clean physical layers with a slight raised edge. This is how you get dimensional flowers, faces, layered graphics.

3.4 • Technique 4 • Piped detail on dry base

Once the flood is dry, switch to stiff icing and pipe details on top — text, dots, lines, small ornaments. The dry base holds the detail cleanly. Ninety-five percent of the "professional" look comes from this step.

3.5 • Technique 5 • Painted royal icing

Once a flooded cookie is fully dry (24 hours ideal), you can paint on it with a fine brush and a mixture of gel colour thinned with clear alcohol (vodka or white rum — the alcohol evaporates and leaves the pigment). This is how you produce watercolour

florals, ombré backgrounds and hand-drawn faces. Learning curve is steep — spend a weekend on scrap cookies before you charge for painted work.

3.6 • Technique 6 • Sprinkles and edible pearls (wet-fix)

Sprinkles applied to wet flood, tapped off after 30 seconds, look like they belong on the cookie. Applied to dry cookies with piped icing "glue," they look stuck on. Always plan the sprinkle drop within the flood window.

3.7 • Technique 7 • Edible transfers (royal icing decals)

Piped icing designs made on parchment or acetate, dried flat for 24-48 hours, then peeled off and placed onto a wet or slightly damp cookie. This is how you get high-detail, repeatable elements (a small monogram, a logo, a flower) that would take five minutes each piped directly onto every cookie. Master this and your \$ per hour doubles.

3.8 • Technique 8 • Monograms and text

Hand-piped or transfer-based initials and short words. For custom orders, always ask the customer for the initial in a font and size you can screenshot. Print it, place it under a light table (or your window during the day) and trace it directly onto a dry flooded cookie with stiff icing and a #1 tip. Practise on the parchment first — the customer's order is not the place to freehand.

3.9 • Technique 9 • Textures (stipple, brush embroidery, ruffles)

Advanced. Stiff icing pushed and pulled with a damp brush to imitate brush strokes, fabric folds, feather patterns. Time-intensive. Only offer this on premium orders where the ticket justifies 15 minutes per cookie.

3.10 • Technique 10 • Airbrush

Requires a small airbrush kit (\$60-90) and gel colours specifically labelled for airbrush use. Fastest way to lay down ombré backgrounds, night skies, stencilled patterns. Not essential — most home bakers reach \$2,000/month revenue without ever touching an airbrush.

THE 3-COOKIE ORDER ARC

For your first year of orders, most of your customers will ask for three cookies per party favour: a monogrammed cookie (Technique 8), a themed shape (Techniques 1 + 4), and a decorative filler (Techniques 2 or 3). If you can execute those three cleanly you have a business. The rest is upsell territory.

Drying and preserving finished pieces

The window between "just finished decorating" and "handed to the customer" is where most home bakers lose product. Here's how to protect it.

A decorated cookie is a fragile edible artwork. It cracks, absorbs humidity, browns and stains. Every one of those failures has a preventable cause.

4.1 • How long does royal icing take to fully harden?

STAGE	TIME FROM FLOODING	WHAT YOU CAN DO
Skin forms on surface	15-30 min	Sprinkles won't stick anymore; wet-on-wet window is closed
Touch-dry	1-2 hours	Can gently move cookies, no piping on top yet
Ready for piped detail	8 hours (overnight ideal)	Add text, dots, borders on dry flood
Fully hardened	18-24 hours	Ready to stack, package, deliver

Every one of those times gets longer if humidity is above 60%. In a humid climate (US Gulf Coast, UK autumn, Australian coastal summer) plan an extra 25-40% drying time or invest in a small dehumidifier for your drying area (\$40 gets you a decent countertop unit).

4.2 • What kills a decorated cookie

- **Humidity above 65%.** Icing goes soft, colours run, surfaces feel tacky.
- **Direct sunlight.** Fades colours, particularly reds and pinks.
- **Kitchen heat above 25 °C / 77 °F.** Icing sweats.
- **Icing browning.** After 3-4 days, royal icing on a rich buttery cookie can develop small brown spots where the butter oxidises through the sugar. Prevention: package airtight with a food-safe silica gel packet within 24 hours of decoration.
- **Cookie-to-cookie contact.** Iced pieces stacked or touching will chip each other.

4.3 • Storage that works

- Individual heat-sealed cellophane bag per cookie (bag + a \$12 impulse sealer from Amazon).
- One food-safe silica gel packet per 6-8 cookies in the box.
- Rigid box (kraft or bakery box) with the cookies sitting flat, not stacked.
- Stored at room temperature, dark, dry. **Never fridge or freeze finished decorated cookies** — condensation destroys the icing surface.

4.4 · Real shelf life of a decorated cookie

Sealed as above, decorated cookies stay at their best for **2 weeks** and remain edible up to **4 weeks**. On your labels put "best by [date + 14 days]." Do not promise 4-6 weeks even though the cookie technically lasts — the icing surface starts losing sharpness after week 2 and customers will notice.

NEVER SEND A CUSTOMER A COOKIE YOU BAKED MORE THAN 10 DAYS AGO

Your customer will hold onto it for another 3-5 days before serving it at the party. Then it sits on the dessert table for another few hours before being eaten. If you sent it at day 10, the eater is enjoying it at day 15 minimum. Cap your production-to-delivery pipeline at 7 days from bake to hand-off.

Presentation — single, gift box, dessert table

The three sales tiers. Each has a fixed ticket range and a fixed way you present the finished order.

Bonus 4 covers packaging in production-manual detail. This module is the overview and the pricing tiers that map to each format.

5.1 • Tier 1 • Individual cookie in a cellophane bag (\$4-6 USD)

The entry price. Cellophane bag, ribbon or tag, single silica pack. Good for corporate favours, wedding welcome gifts, giveaways, small orders under 12 pieces.

5.2 • Tier 2 • Themed gift box of 6-12 cookies (\$40-95 USD)

Kraft box with a clear window, tissue paper base, individual cellophane per cookie, a printed thank-you card, silica pack. This is your bread-and-butter offering. 70% of your orders will be this tier once you're established.

5.3 • Tier 3 • Full dessert table / dozens delivered on trays (\$200-800 USD)

Custom trays, matched packaging suites, coordinated colours, delivery and on-site setup. Bigger tickets, more logistics, higher margin. You'll grow into this once your reputation carries.

Pricing and selling — closing the loop

The formula, the sales channels and the way you actually convert an inquiry into a paid order. This is where the method becomes a business.

Bonus 5 gives you the full four-layer pricing formula in printable worksheet form. This module is the overview and the sales-channel map. Read both.

6.1 • The base pricing formula (short version)

Every decorated cookie needs to earn you all four of the following costs — miss any one and you're subsidising your customer:

1. **Direct ingredient cost** (flour, butter, sugar, colours, icing, sprinkles) — usually \$0.35-0.70 per cookie.
2. **Indirect cost** (gas, electricity, packaging, cellophane, silica, box, ribbon) — usually \$0.50-1.10 per cookie.
3. **Your hourly rate x time per cookie** — for a decorated cookie, 8-15 minutes of active time. At \$18-25/hr for a beginner, that's \$2.50-6 per cookie.
4. **Profit margin** — 20-35% on top of costs 1+2+3. This is the money you actually keep.

For a mid-complexity 3-inch decorated cookie the resulting retail price lands between **\$5.50 and \$9 USD**, with UK and Australian markets typically 10-25% higher due to ingredient and packaging import costs.

6.2 • Where you sell — the sales-channel stack

- **Personal network (weeks 1-4)**: family, friends, coworkers. Your first ten buyers come from here. Bonus 1 covers exactly how.
- **Instagram DMs and Reels (months 2-6)**: the single highest-converting channel for decorated cookies. Post finished orders with the customer's permission, tag your location, use event-based hashtags.
- **Facebook local groups (months 3+)**: neighbourhood groups, mums' groups, local buy-nothing groups (as an occasional treat post, not spam).
- **Etsy (months 6+)**: only when you have a portfolio of 20+ photographed orders. Higher fees, higher discoverability.
- **Word-of-mouth (from month 3, permanently after)**: the compounding engine. Every party you deliver to has 20-40 attendees, half of whom will remember your cookies six weeks later when they have their own event.

6.3 • The inquiry-to-cash workflow

1. Inquiry arrives (DM, text, email, referral).
2. Reply within **4 business hours** — 80% of orders go to whoever replies first.
3. Ask five questions: date needed by, quantity, theme/colours, allergies, delivery or pickup.
4. Send a quote with a specific total, delivery date, and 50% deposit request. Offer Stripe / PayPal / Venmo / cash — never bank transfer only.
5. Deposit arrives → order is confirmed. No deposit = no order.
6. Produce and package.
7. Send a "your order is ready" photo the day before pickup/delivery.
8. Hand off, collect the remaining 50% at handoff.

9. Follow up 3-5 days later asking for permission to post the photo and requesting a review.

THE DEPOSIT RULE IS NON-NEGOTIABLE

Never start production without a 50% deposit. The one time you skip it, that's the order that cancels the day before pickup, leaving you with 48 custom cookies that fit no other buyer. Every professional home baker learns this once. Learn it from this PDF instead of from a cancelled wedding order.

CLOSING

Your next week with this method

The exact seven-day plan that turns this PDF from theory into your first paying order.

You've read the method. Here is the week that separates the students who ended up with a business from the ones who filed the PDF in a folder called "someday."

DAY	WHAT YOU DO	TIME
Monday	Read Bonus 2 (Sourcing Supplies), build your shopping list, place the online order or plan a supermarket run.	45 min
Tuesday-Wednesday	Supplies arrive. Set up your workspace. Prep your kitchen scale, parchment, freezer space.	30 min
Thursday	Bake one full batch of Module 1 vanilla recipe. 24 cookies undecorated.	2 hr
Friday	Mix one batch of royal icing (Module 2). Practise the three consistencies. No decorating yet.	1 hr
Saturday	Decorate all 24 test cookies using Techniques 1, 2 and 4. Photograph the six best.	4 hr
Sunday	Open Bonus 1 (First 10 Buyers). Personalise the outreach scripts. Send to 10 people in your immediate network.	45 min

WHAT HAPPENS IF YOU ACTUALLY DO THIS WEEK

By the end of week two you'll have at least one paid order in the queue. By week four you'll have three to five. By month three you'll be at your first "I can't take any more orders this week" moment — and that's when you go back and reread Module 4 (batch production) and Bonus 3 (preservation) properly.

The method works. It's been walked by thousands of home bakers in the US, UK, Canada and Australia before you. The only variable is whether you actually run the seven-day plan above.

Now close this PDF and open Bonus 2. Your shopping list is waiting.

See you on Monday

*This is the moment where a course becomes a business.
Everything you need is already in this pack. The rest is you and
your Saturday.*

Bookmark your access hub

All six PDFs plus the five bonuses are in one page — the pack hub
link you were sent. Save it now, before you close this window.